Fusion of functions revisited: Independent determinatives in English

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Abstract

When does one constituent have two functions at once? *The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language* treats *some* in *take some* as both determiner and head of its noun phrase, and *few* in *the lucky few* and *rich* in *the rich* as both modifier and head. Payne et al. (2007) make this fusion of functions explicit and build their case on *once*, *twice*, and *thrice*. The alternative is to treat the word as a head and nothing more. To choose between the two analyses, this paper proposes a test: a property of form counts as evidence for a second function if it varies with that function rather than with the word. Using the grammar's own diagnostics and corpus data from COCA, NOW, and iWeb, I find no such property for the modifier function or in Payne et al.'s constructions, and one for the determiner function: the absence of an adjective before a bare determinative (**Lucky few escaped*). That one fact, which has an exception, doesn't outweigh the generality of treating the word as a head. Fused relatives are different. Subject relativization, the ban on infinitival forms, and a preference in case all reflect the relative word's function inside its clause. Fusion is favoured there, though not forced, and nowhere else.

Keywords: determinatives; fused heads; headedness; noun phrase; quantifiers; English grammar

AI use. The large language models GPT-6 (Astra), Claude Fable 5.1, Claude Opus 5 and 5.5, Claude Haiku 4.5, GLM-5.3-Flash, Muse Wonder 1.0, and GPT-5.6 (Sol) served as drafting and editing aids throughout the preparation of this paper. I am responsible for all theoretical claims, arguments, errors, and interpretive choices.

1 Introduction

When one expression seems to have two functions at once, what should persuade us that it does? In *some apples*, *some* determines the noun phrase, and the noun *apples* is its head. In *I'll take* [*some*], *some* is the whole noun phrase, and there's no noun to be its head. One influential analysis gives *some* both functions there: it's the determiner of its noun phrase and the phrase's head at once. This paper asks what evidence could justify that doubling.

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Two distinctions run through it. A word's category is the set it belongs to, such as noun, determinative, or adjective. Its function is the relation it bears in its phrase, such as head, determiner, or modifier. So *some* is a determinative in both examples, and what's at issue is its functions.

The doubling is called FUSION OF FUNCTIONS. Its most explicit statements are in *The Cambridge Grammar of the English Language* (*CGEL*; Huddleston and Pullum, 2002) and in Payne et al. (2007). In *take some*, *CGEL*'s *some* is a fused determiner-head. In *the lucky few* and *the rich*, *few* and *rich* are fused modifier-heads, at once modifier and head (pp. 410–421). Payne et al. make the device explicit, extend it to *once*, *twice*, and *thrice*, and say what it costs.

It departs from canonical structure twice. A constituent with two functions "will in effect have two mothers", which they call "the major departure from canonical principles of structure" (p. 570). And the head of a noun phrase can turn out to be a determinative or an adjective, not a noun, "the second departure" (p. 571). The question is when a grammar should accept the first.

Many syntacticians would sidestep it. The determinative could head the whole noun phrase, as on the DP hypothesis (see Miller & Pullum, 2022; Salzmann, 2020), or a silent noun could follow *some* (Kester, 1996; Lobeck, 1995). Each route gives up one of three commitments *CGEL* argues for (Section 2): where a noun phrase has a noun, the noun is its head and the determinative a dependent; *some* keeps its category when it stands alone; and there's no silent head noun. This paper keeps all three, since they're the premises that led to fusion, and asks whether fusion follows from them. It doesn't. The result is conditional on those commitments, but the criterion behind it applies to a second function in any analysis.

The alternative I call ORDINARY HEAD. The phrase that *CGEL* fuses has one function, head of the NOMINAL, as a common noun does in *take* [*apples*]. The nominal is the unit between noun and noun phrase, such as *old man* in *the old man*. Since the two analyses describe the same strings, choosing between them takes a criterion, and I put the burden on the second function. A property of form counts as evidence for it if it varies with that function and not with the word alone, and the evidence is weighed against the extra structure (Section 2).

The test finds no such property where a word that's elsewhere a modifier in a nominal heads the nominal itself, as in *the lucky few*, *the rich*, and *nylon* in *I prefer cotton shirts to* [*nylon*] (Section 4), nor in *once*, *twice*, and *thrice*, on which Payne et al. built their case (Section 5). Where a determinative stands alone, as in *take some*, it finds one, taken up below, and no other (Section 3). The genitive, the form *CGEL* ties to a fused determiner-head (p. 420), divides these words one by one, not by function, both standing alone and after a determiner. Payne et al.'s term-of-office *once* and *twice* (*the once mayor*, *the twice president*) come out as ordinary modifiers.

The one property the test finds is the absence of an adjective before a bare determinative (**Lucky few escaped*). Fusion derives it, where ordinary Head has to state it as a condition, one of a kind *CGEL* already states for pronouns, so it counts as evidence for the determiner function. It's one fact, though, with an exception in *Poor everybody!*, and Section 6 weighs it against the generality ordinary Head gains and the constituents with two parents it avoids. On balance, then, the phrase *CGEL* fuses is an ordinary head, though the evidence doesn't force that conclusion.

Fused relatives are another matter (Section 7). In [*Whoever told you that*] *can't have read the report carefully*, *whoever* is head of the subject noun phrase and also the subject of *told you that* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1076). On the alternative, the relative word simply heads the noun phrase and the clause modifies it (Bresnan & Grimshaw, 1978). But the second function shows in form,

twice categorically and once as a preference. Fused relatives relativize their subject, which bare relatives in standard English can't do. They're never infinitival, though relatives without a relative word can be. And the form of *who* and *whoever* tends to answer to the function inside the clause. Fusion gets all three from the rules for relative clauses with a relative phrase, where the head analysis needs licences no other head has. So fusion is favoured there, though not forced, and it's the one construction where this paper keeps it.

2 Two analyses and a criterion

The framework keeps categories apart from functions. A category is a set of words or phrases, such as noun, determinative, or adjective. A function is the relation a constituent bears within its phrase, such as head, determiner, or modifier. The two vary independently: *nylon* is a noun functioning as head in *made of* [*nylon*] and as modifier in *a* [*nylon*] *shirt* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 421), and an NP functions as determiner in [*Kim's*] *book*.

So DETERMINATIVE names a category (*the*, *this*, *some*, *every*, *many*), and DETERMINER names a function.[1] Figure 1a gives *CGEL*'s structure for *some apples*. The determinative heads a determinative phrase (DP) that functions as determiner (Det) of the NP.[2] The noun heads the NOMINAL (Nom), the unit between noun and NP, and the nominal is the NP's head. *CGEL* recognizes the unit because *old man* in *the old man* is neither a noun nor an NP, since it can't function as subject or object (p. 329). I write "nominal" in prose and Nom in trees and quotations. The NP's ULTIMATE HEAD is the word reached by following head relations down from the NP: *apples* in Figure 1a, *some* in b and c.

[1] One more function is used from Section 3 on. A PERIPHERAL MODIFIER modifies a whole NP, determiner included, as *even* does in [*even*] *this house* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 331).

[2] DP here is *CGEL*'s determinative phrase, a phrase whose head is a determinative, not the DP of the DP hypothesis, on which the determinative heads the whole noun phrase. Miller and Pullum (2022) draw the same distinction. Payne et al. (2007, 566 n. 2), like *CGEL*, take the noun as head of the NP.

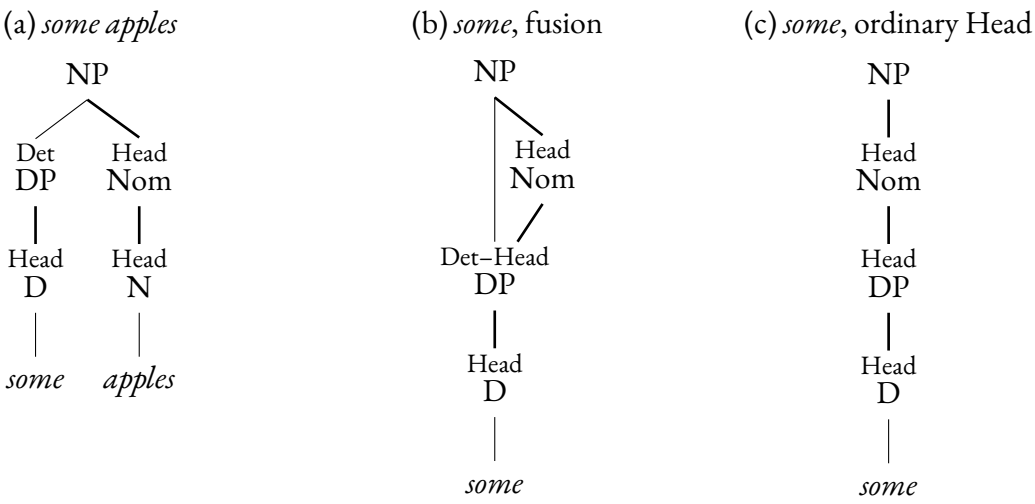


Figure 1: *Some apples* (a), and *some* standing alone under fusion (b) and ordinary Head (c). Function labels sit above category labels, and thick lines join heads to their parents. In (b) the DP has two parents, with a line from the NP for its determiner function and one from the nominal for its head function. In (c) it's the head of the nominal and nothing else. Each tree shows the DP even where it contains only D, so that the same constituent appears in all three.

Without a noun, as in *I'll take* [*some*], the nominal still needs a head. *CGEL*'s answer is fusion of functions: the DP functions as determiner and as head at once, a fused determiner-head (Det–Head; Figure 1b) (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 410–421). After a determiner, as in *the lucky few*, the word is a fused modifier-head (Mod–Head). Payne et al. (2007) make the device explicit and list where English uses it: "The subtypes of dependent involved are determiner, modifier and, in fused relative clauses, subject or prenucleus" (p. 571). Sections 3, 4 and 7 take them in that order, and Section 5 takes Payne et al.'s own case, *once*, *twice*, and *thrice*.

Fusion, as Payne et al. define it, departs from canonical structure in two ways. First, one constituent has two functions, so that it "will in effect have two mothers", which they call "the major departure from canonical principles of structure" (p. 570). The structure is then a directed acyclic graph rather than a tree (Pullum & Rogers, 2008), and the CGELBank treebank gives such a constituent a hyphenated label for its two parents (Reynolds et al., 2025, §3.2). In Det–Head the shared DP has two parents, the NP and the nominal; in Mod–Head both functions belong to one nominal (pp. 582, 588). Second, an NP can have an ultimate head of another category: the fused node is "a point in the normal path of headedness at which there can be a change of category" (p. 569).

Ordinary Head keeps the second departure and drops the first. Whatever phrase *CGEL* fuses functions as head of the nominal and nothing else: a DP for *some* (Figure 1c) and for *few* in *the lucky few*, an AdjP in *the rich*. For adjectives this is the traditional analysis: "Adjectives can function as heads of noun phrases" (Quirk et al., 1985, p. 421). A determiner before it, as *the* in *the rich*, is the NP's determiner as usual, and the nominal keeps its other dependents: in *few of them* the *of*-phrase is a complement in the nominal headed by *few*, as in *CGEL*'s own partitive tree (pp. 411–412). What fusion states as a licence for a fused function, ordinary Head states as a permission: a word may head a nominal, with or without a determiner before it. *Some* may head one with no determiner, and *rich* one after *the*.

CGEL has a term for a head of this kind: the independent genitive pronouns "occur in fused heads and also pure heads" (p. 410), a pure head being one with no second function. It also considers the analysis, as "change of function without change of category", with *many* a determiner in [*Many*] *people would agree with you* and a head in [*Many*] *would agree with you* (p. 421).

The change of category needs no new kind of structure. Payne et al. say it "will be independently required in the case of hybrid constructions" (p. 571), and their tree for *there's* [*no stopping him*] has a VP as head of an NP whose determiner is *no*: "an unexpected category appears as head … However, there is no fusion of functions in this case" (p. 600). The tree shares the two properties that matter here, an unexpected category as head and no constituent with two functions, though the VP heads the NP directly, with no nominal between. Payne et al. find hybrids "only marginally in English" (p. 566). But ordinary Head changes category in exactly the constructions where fusion does, at the same node, so it uses no departure that fusion doesn't also use, and uses it no more widely.

Both analyses keep three commitments that *CGEL* argues for, and the comparison holds them fixed. First, where an NP has a noun, the noun is its head, and the determinative is a dependent, as in *some apples*. Second, the determinative keeps its category when it stands alone: it takes the dependents it takes before a noun (*not much cheese*, *not much of the cheese*), which "argues against any part-of-speech distinction between the two uses" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 420). Third, there's no silent head noun. Analyses that give up one of these avoid fusion by other means: a determiner phrase headed by the determinative, or a silent noun.[3] This paper doesn't take those analyses on. Its result is conditional: given *CGEL*'s commitments, fusion is needed only in fused relatives.

Since both analyses describe the same strings, the comparison needs a criterion. What they disagree about is structure, so the evidence that can decide between them is form, and *CGEL* itself takes form as the sign of a function when it argues from the genitive (p. 420). Payne et al. call a constituent with two functions a departure from canonical structure, so I take the burden to lie with the second function. Where the same category and head relation account for an expression, a property of form counts as evidence for a second function if it varies with that function and not with the word alone. By form I mean the shape of words (a case form, or a form like *none* that, in an NP, occurs only standing alone), order, and which dependents and determiners a word takes. Interpretation alone isn't form. *CGEL* keeps the two apart elsewhere. In *She considered Ed* [*quite competent*], the adjective

[3] On the DP hypothesis the determinative heads the phrase (see Miller & Pullum, 2022; Salzmann, 2020), and pronouns can be analysed as determiners (Postal, 1966); Payne et al. believe their fusion analysis of *once* "not compatible with the 'DP hypothesis', or at least that the hypothesis renders it difficult to find an appropriate analysis" (p. 566 n. 2). Silent nouns come in two kinds. On ellipsis analyses a noun is recovered from an antecedent (Lobeck, 1995). On empty-noun analyses a null noun with general content, such as HUMAN, needs none (Kester, 1996; Panagiotidis, 2003; Saab, 2019). Kayne (2007) gives *few* a silent NUMBER, and Aarts (2024) proposes empty heads in place of fusion. Wu (2021) argues that no single analysis covers noun phrases without a head noun, and puts an empty noun after *the rich* and after a determinative standing alone. He considers adjective and determinative heads and rejects them, since a head should share its phrase's category and a bare adjective can't show number or genericity (pp. 19–20, 118, 173). Ordinary Head makes the adjective head of the nominal, not of the NP; its change of category is Payne et al.'s second departure, which fusion shares; and *the rich* is plural with no plural ending on every analysis, as Wu grants for his empty noun (p. 118 n. 14). *CGEL*'s grounds against a silent head are that partitives have no noun to restore (**many ones of us*, **much quantity of it*); that *the rich* is generic and *the rich people* isn't; and that the NP construction lacks the marks of gapping, since it isn't confined to coordination and can't omit a sequence that isn't a constituent (pp. 420–421). Payne et al. (2007, 571 n. 5) add that a null head needs stipulations that adjacency makes unnecessary.

phrase is predicated of *Ed*, which is the object of *considered*, and *CGEL* calls *Ed* the adjective phrase's PREDICAND, a semantic relation, not its subject, a syntactic one (pp. 217, 252).

The criterion answers *CGEL*'s one objection to ordinary Head. *Nylon* in *I prefer cotton shirts to* [*nylon*] is one of *CGEL*'s fused modifier-heads, of the type denoting composition (p. 417). *CGEL* rejects analysing it as a noun functioning simply as head, since that "would not distinguish this construction from *I prefer cotton to nylon*", where *nylon* isn't "understood as having modifier function" (p. 421). The difference is real. But the word is the same in both sentences, and so is its form: bare *nylon* as the object of *to*. What differs is what the context supplies.

The one formal property *CGEL* ties to these modifier-heads is their determiners. The NPs of *nylon*'s type "are either bare or have a definite determiner", with "significant loss of acceptability when the determiner is indefinite" (p. 417), and nouns of other types are excluded, as in **Bill likes the linguistics lecturer, but I prefer* [*the sociology*] (p. 415). The examples in (1) cross both lines.

(1) a. *You take the cat shirt and I'll take* [*the dog*].
b. **You take the cat shirt and I'll take* [*dog*].
c. *I bought a cat shirt rather than* [*a dog*].
d. *You take the cotton shirt and I'll take* [*nylon*].
e. *Choose a metal-bladed version rather than* [*nylon*], *as the latter will probably snap* (growveg.com, iWeb)
f. *... to look more like a kitchen sink rather than* [*a bathroom*] (thefarmersnest.com, 2012, COCA)
g. *punishing people convicted of drug possession with a misdemeanor sentence rather than* [*a felony*] (*Arizona Daily Star*, 2019, COCA)

Dog, *bathroom*, and *felony* belong to no type *CGEL* lists, and they work. Bare *dog* is out and *a dog* is fine, as for a singular count noun generally. Non-count *nylon* stands bare for a single item and resists *a* (?*I bought a cotton shirt rather than* [*a nylon*], p. 417). So the determiners follow the noun's own countability. Both analyses make the noun the head, so both predict that. A silent head doesn't: every antecedent in (1) is a count noun, so a head that took its features would reject bare *nylon*, and a head with none of its own wouldn't exclude bare *dog*. What the facts don't show is anything that varies with the modifier function, and the restriction *CGEL* states for it doesn't hold.[4] On this criterion, nothing here counts as evidence for the modifier function.[5]

CGEL also names a form that a second function would show. A fused determiner-head should resist the genitive, because "for full acceptability its case should match both functions" (p. 420), and

[4] Dependents give the same result. Matthews (2014, pp. 28–29) notes that material nouns used as modifiers take degree words such as *partly* and *largely* (*a partly cotton shirt*, *largely glass walls*), and suggests they're adjectives there. The fused use takes them (*I prefer pure cotton shirts to* [*partly nylon*]), but so do uses with no modifier function: *I prefer cotton to* [*partly nylon*], where the noun names the material, and *This lava is* [*partly magma*] (conserve-energy-future.com). So *partly* isn't tied to the modifier function.

[5] *CGEL*'s other example, *Mary earns* [*double*] (p. 421), fuses a noun with a predeterminer modifier (p. 418), and *double* gets the treatment *nylon* gets. Its category fits. Before a definite determiner, *CGEL*'s predeterminers are nouns and NPs (*half the cake*, *double the number of applications*) or the adverb *twice* (p. 434), and my searches of the Corpus of Contemporary American English (COCA; Davies, 2008–present) found no adjective phrase there, apart from one marginal *400-fold the amount* (a blog, 2012).

CGEL points to case in fused relatives, where the form of *whoever* or *whomever* reflects its function inside the relative clause (pp. 1073–1074). That's a test the later sections can run. Among fused determiner-heads, *either's* is fine and *many's* all but absent, though *CGEL* gives both words the same two functions (Section 3). After a preposition, *whomever* is chosen far more often when it isn't the subject of the relative clause, though its function in the main clause stays the same (Section 7). The first difference follows the word, the second the function.

The criterion says what counts as evidence for a second function, not how much is enough. A property of form can favour fusion without settling the matter, and an exception weakens the evidence without erasing it. So the later sections compare the analyses construction by construction: what each predicts, where the data go against a prediction, what each has to state instead, and what the extra structure buys. Where the data can't separate the analyses, I say so, since finding no evidence for a second function isn't finding evidence against it. The standard also applies to what this paper adds. Its analysis of *a few* rests on number (Section 4), and the licences ordinary Head needs for fused relatives count against it (Section 7).

A note on data. Examples are *CGEL*'s or Payne et al.'s where cited, attested where a source is given, and otherwise constructed. Judgments not attributed to a source are mine. As in *CGEL*, * marks an unacceptable form, ?a questionable one, !a non-standard one, and %one found only in some varieties. Corpus lines come from COCA, the Corpus of News on the Web (NOW; Davies, 2016–present), and the iWeb corpus (Davies, 2018), searched by hand at english-corpora.org between 15 and 18 October 2026; where a display was capped, counts are of the lines shown. Some sets of lines were classified by a large language model (Claude Opus 5.5), and each line's label is kept so that the classification can be checked. The model labelled the genitive lines in Section 3 twice, in separate runs, the second without access to the first's labels, and the two runs found the same genitives. The record behind each corpus claim, with its query, date, counts, and labels, is listed in an evidence index.

3 Determinatives standing alone: Det–Head

A determinative can make up a whole noun phrase, or head one that also contains a complement or modifier, and so can an independent genitive such as *mine* (e):

(2) a. *I'll take* [*some*].
b. [*Few*] *would dare underestimate Aaron Finch's men.*
c. *some of the wine*, *many of them*, *whichever of them*
d. *hardly anyone present*, *something reliable*
e. [*Mine*] *are ready.*

For *CGEL* each of these has a fused Det–Head: one phrase functions at once as determiner of the NP and as head of its nominal (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 410–423). On ordinary Head it's a pure head, with no second function (Section 2). The question here is whether anything in the form of these expressions shows the determiner function.

Some things aren't at issue. Both analyses take these to be complete NPs with no silent noun. They have the functions of NPs (*Some left*, *I see some*, *with some*), there's no noun to restore (**many*

ones of us; pp. 420–421), and often there's none in the context either.[6] Nor is the lack of a further determiner evidence for the determiner function. *CGEL* gives *She left*, *Kim left*, and *People left* NPs with no determiner, and ordinary Head gives *Some left* the same structure.

Partitives add nothing here. In *some of the wine*, the *of* -phrase is a complement inside the nominal (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 411–412), so *some* is the ultimate head on either analysis. The claim about bare uses extends to them unchanged, including *whichever of them* in the fused relative of Section 7. So do relative clauses.[7]

CGEL and Payne et al. (2007) point to three places where the determiner function might show: the correspondence with the determiner use; the forms of *none*, *mine*, and the compounds; and case. None of them shows it. One fact of distribution does favour fusion, and it comes with the compounds.

First, the correspondence. *CGEL* keeps the determiner function because the word "can occur in the dependent position in NPs where it is not fused with the head" (p. 410). It keeps the category because the word takes the same dependents in both uses (*not much cheese*, *not much of the cheese*; pp. 420–421). Ordinary Head keeps the category, and with it both facts: *much* is the same determinative in both uses, and it takes the dependents a determinative takes.

What the correspondence adds beyond the category is a list of the determinatives that can stand alone. *Some*, *each*, and *either* can, and *every* normally can't (**every of the students*), though two published cases have turned up (*Every has a story*, *Patch*, 2025); *no* does so only in the form *none*. Payne et al. (2007, p. 581) state the list as a "lexical distinction between determinatives that allow [fusion of functions] and those that do not". Ordinary Head states the same list as a permission to head a nominal with no determiner. Neither analysis gets it free.

CGEL considers ordinary Head too, as "change of function without change of category", and rejects it because *nylon* in *I prefer cotton shirts to* [*nylon*] is "understood as having modifier function" (p. 421). Section 2 answers that objection: an interpretation alone doesn't establish a syntactic function. For determinatives the objection has a further gap. It contrasts a word's use as a pure head with its fused use, and *CGEL* gives determinatives no use as a pure head.

Second, form. Payne et al. find formal differences between fused and non-fused functions here, as in fused relatives: *no* "has a specialized morphological variant *none* which is restricted to the fused function" (p. 581). A difference of form doesn't say which function it marks, though, and the genitive pronouns supply the test. They alternate the same way (*my*, *mine*), and *CGEL* states the conditioning for both pairs at once: "the dependent forms are used in (pure) determiner function, the independent ones in head function" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 410).

Mine occurs with a determiner function and without one. The independent genitive pronouns "occur in fused heads and also pure heads" (p. 410), pure heads being heads with no second function, and predicative *mine* in *Everything that is* [*mine*] *is yours* has "no basis for a fused-head analysis" (p. 469). Its form is the same, so the form marks the head function. *None* has no pure-head use

[6] Of 94 NOW lines for *few would*, 82 have no noun phrase or named set in the displayed context that could supply the set, as in (2b) (*Daily Times*, Pakistan, 20 October 2022); 3 have one, 2 probably do, and 7 can't be decided from the window.

[7] Wu (2021, pp. 184–185) finds a dilemma for fusion in *For* [*some who made the journey into Wales*]*, the experience was profound* (BNC): fusion makes *some*, a determiner, the antecedent of the relative clause, against the principle that determiners don't count as antecedents, and he adds an empty noun to resolve it. On ordinary Head, *some* heads the nominal and the relative clause modifies that nominal, with nothing added.

to test (p. 410), so its form is assigned to the same conditioning on the model of *mine*, not shown independently. Ordinary Head then states both alternations as *CGEL* does, by function: Det against Head.

Compounds raise the question of form again. *CGEL* analyses *anyone*, *something*, and the rest as fused determiner-heads (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 423). Payne et al. take them to be determinatives because "they take exactly the same pre-head modifiers as the determinative bases they contain" (p. 581): *not everything* beside *not every house*, *hardly anyone present* beside *hardly any writer present*. That fixes the category, which ordinary Head keeps.

On ordinary Head, *not* and *hardly* are modifiers of the whole NP, the kind *CGEL* calls peripheral (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 430–431), and the compound's base still decides which ones it takes. Payne et al. also take the compounds' morphology, a determinative base with a nominal base, to mirror fusion (pp. 565, 587–588). What the two bases mirror is the compound's meaning, a quantifier with a sort ('person', 'thing'), and both analyses give it that meaning. Simple *some* and *few* have no nominal base, and for Payne et al. they're fused just the same.[8]

The compounds' modifiers divide by side: adverbs before, adjectives after (*anyone present*, *something reliable*). The adjective is a post-head restrictor that doesn't recur (p. 583), and Payne et al. (2007, p. 583) count fusion's account of the division "a particular strength". On ordinary Head the adjective is a restrictor inside the nominal, and the analyses differ only in grouping: ordinary Head gives [*hardly* [*anyone present*]], fusion [[*hardly anyone*] *present*].

CGEL's peripheral modifiers can scope over a whole NP, as in *After* [*hardly a moment's hesitation*] *he agreed* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 437), so a fusion grammar can assign the first grouping too, and the grouping doesn't decide between them.[9]

The other half of the division does favour fusion, and it's the one trace of the determiner function in the distribution of these words. Bare determinatives take no pre-head adjective (**nice anyone*, **Lucky few escaped*), apart from a few exclamations such as *Poor everybody!* (Section 4). With the determiner and head functions fused, an adjective would have to come before the determiner, so fusion derives the gap from adjacency, where ordinary Head has to state it, as an analysis with a silent head does (Payne et al., 2007, p. 584).

The adjective is fine once a determiner precedes (*the lucky few*). It's also fine in *a lucky few*, which *CGEL*'s analyses of *a few* allow two ways (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 353, 392). Section 4 shows that on either way the adjective doesn't come before a bare determinative, so the gap stands.

Third, case, where *CGEL* itself says the determiner function would show. In *many people's expenses*, the genitive *'s* attaches to *people*, the head of *many people's*, and not to its determiner, *many*. On the fused analysis a bare *many* is both head and determiner, so **many's expenses* would put the genitive on a determiner. *CGEL* reports that very gap, calling *all's*, *many's*, *few's*, and *some's* "completely excluded". Its explanation is fusion: "the form is simultaneously determiner and head, and for full acceptability its case should match both functions" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 420).

CGEL offers this against analysing these words as pronouns, an analysis that gives no reason for the gap (p. 420). Ordinary Head gives no reason either, so the argument bears on it too, and it's the most direct of the three.

[8] Payne et al.'s own note treats the nominal base of *once* as a reanalysis of a genitive ending (p. 588 n. 30); see Section 5.

[9] Trees for both analyses of *hardly anyone present* are in the online supplement.

For *all*, *many*, *few*, and *some*, the gap is all but complete in usage,[10] but it doesn't hold across the fused determiner-heads. *Either's*, *neither's*, and *each's* occur in edited prose, and I find them acceptable: *won't substantially increase* [*either's*] *share of its market* (*TIME*, 2000), [*Neither's*] *numbers are all that encouraging* (*Washington Post*, 2014), *the highlight of* [*each's*] *day* (*Atlantic*, 1995). *CGEL* calls *each's* "occasionally attested but of somewhat questionable status" (p. 420), but COCA has twelve genitives of *each* and seventeen of *either*.

CGEL's own examples of genitive marking on the head include *everyone's* and *somebody's* (p. 479), compounds it analyses as fused determiner-heads (p. 423). A defender of fusion could put their genitive down to the nominal base, *-one* or *-body*.

So the genitive divides these words, and neither analysis predicts where the division falls. Each states it with a list. Fusion predicts the gap for every fused determiner-head, so it has to exempt *either*, *neither*, *each*, and the compounds unless their nominal base carries the genitive. Ordinary Head expects a head to take the genitive, so it has to list the words that don't, as it lists the reflexive pronouns, which have no genitive either (p. 426). Which list is shorter isn't the question, though. The criterion asks whether the form varies with a function.

Here it doesn't. On *CGEL*'s analysis these words all have the same two functions, so the functions can't be what puts *many* on one side of the division and *either* on the other. What the form varies with is the word. A comparison that could show a function would keep the word and change its functions, and for these words there's none to make, since *CGEL* gives them no use as a pure head.

Section 7 finds that kind of evidence. After a preposition, *whomever* is chosen over *whoever* far more often when it isn't the subject of the relative clause than when it is. The word and its function in the main clause stay the same, and the form follows the function inside the relative clause. On the diagnostic *CGEL* itself proposes, then, the determiner function doesn't show in fused determiner-heads, and the second function in fused relatives does.

The costs can now be compared. Both analyses list the determinatives that stand alone and the forms *none* and *mine*, and both need a list for the genitive, fusion of the words that have it and ordinary Head of the words that don't. Both change category on the head path, since the NP's ultimate head is a determinative. Payne et al. accept that change for fusion (p. 569), and hybrid constructions need it anyway (p. 571). Fusion adds a constituent with two functions, which they call "the major departure from canonical principles of structure" (pp. 570–571). Ordinary Head adds instead a condition on pre-head adjectives, which fusion derives.

So the trade is a constituent with two functions against one stated condition. Section 4 shows that fusion needs a statement too, for *Poor everybody!*, and that the grammar already makes a statement of this kind for pronouns. Apart from the adjective, nothing in the form of these expressions shows a determiner function. That one fact counts for fusion, and Section 6 weighs it against what ordinary Head gains.

[10] COCA searches for each word followed by *'s*, one search per word, give the following genitives on the word standing alone, out of the lines each search returned: *either* 17 of 30 lines, *neither* 6 of 23, *each* 12 of 12, *many* 3 of 76, *some* 1 of 24, *few* none of 22, and *all* none in a display-capped sample of 499 lines (nine genitives there are on *you all*). The other lines are mostly contractions of *is* or *has* (*Either's fine*, *many's the time*) and names. The counts aren't adjusted for how often each word stands alone. Thirteen of the 35 genitives of *either*, *neither*, and *each* come from edited prose (fiction, magazines, newspapers, academic writing). The four of *many* and *some* all come from the web; two seem fine to me (*to* [*many's*] *suprise* [sic] *he won*, *out of* [*so many's*] *reach*), the other two questionable.

4 Modifiers as heads: Mod–Head

In Mod–Head fusion the head of a nominal is also its modifier. *CGEL* uses it for words that function elsewhere as modifiers in a nominal: determinatives and adjectives, and also nouns such as *nylon* (p. 417), taken up in Section 2:[11]

(3) a. *This copy is defective but* [*the other two*] *are fine.*
b. *I didn't like it myself, but I respect the views of* [*the many who did*].
c. *Are you one of* [*the lucky few who found powdered infant formula*]*?*
d. [*The rich*] *cannot enter the kingdom of Heaven.*
e. *How will the new system affect* [*the very poor*]*?*
f. *There were two pieces left and Kim, as always, chose* [*the larger*].

For *CGEL*, *two*, *many*, *few*, *rich*, *poor*, and *larger* each modify the nominal and head it at once (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 415–419). Payne et al. (2007, pp. 579–580) draw the adjectival case for *the very hard of hearing*: the AdjP is "head of Nom" and "modifier of that head", and *the* is the NP's determiner as usual.[12] Unlike Det–Head, both functions belong to the same nominal (p. 588; Figure 2). Their main Mod–Head case, *this once*, is taken up in Section 5. On ordinary Head the phrase is the head of the nominal and nothing more.

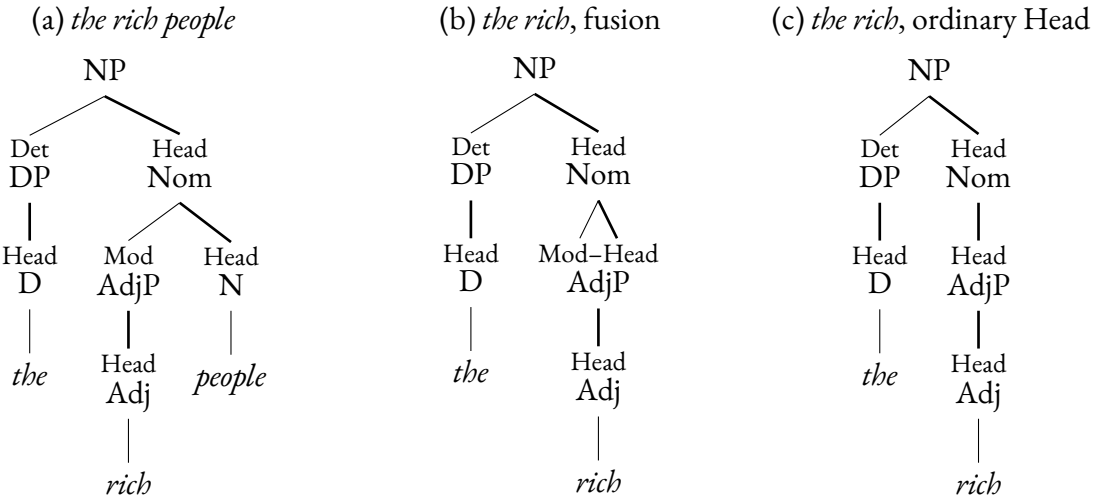


Figure 2: *The rich people* (a), and *the rich* under fusion (b) and ordinary Head (c). In (b) the AdjP has one parent, the nominal, with a line from it for each of its two functions; in Figure 1b the fused DP has two parents. In (c) the AdjP is the head of the nominal and nothing else.

So the two analyses agree that the adjective or determinative heads the nominal. Neither has a noun as the NP's ultimate head, the change of category Payne et al. accept at the fused node (p. 569).

[11] Examples (3a, b, d–f) are *CGEL*'s (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 416–419); (3c) is from NOW (*National Observer*, 3 October 2022).

[12] Payne et al.'s tree labels the fused function Head-Mod, since the counterpart modifier follows the head (*people very hard of hearing*); their tree for *this once* has Mod-Head (p. 588). *CGEL* allows fusion with a post-head modifier as well (p. 418). I write Mod–Head for both.

Both keep the word's category. *Rich* and *poor* take adverbs (*the extremely rich*, *the very poor*), which *CGEL* calls "clear evidence that they retain their category status as adjectives", and *the rich* is plural with no plural ending (p. 418). Both give the head the dependents it takes elsewhere: a partitive in *the biggest of them* (p. 416), a post-head phrase in *the pure in heart* (p. 418). And neither restores a noun: *the people very hard of hearing* can't be read generically, as *the very hard of hearing* is (Payne et al., 2007, p. 580).

What's at issue is only the second function, the modifier. Form could show it in two ways: a form restricted to the fused function, as *none* is for Det–Head, or a fact of order that only a modifier relation predicts. The formal differences Payne et al. cite are in Det–Head and in fused relatives (*none*, p. 581; the *-ever* forms, p. 576), and they cite none for Mod–Head. Their fact of order is adjacency: nothing comes between the fused functions, so **the in the room very hard of hearing* is out (p. 580 n. 17). That argument is aimed at a silent head. With the AdjP as head, the PP would precede the head of a nominal, which PPs don't do before a noun either (**the in the room people*).

For determinatives, *CGEL* links the fused use to the dependent one. Determinatives "which can function as internal modifier as well as determiner can in general occur as fused modifier-head as well as determiner-head" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 415): *the few* beside *the few mistakes*, where *few* is modifier (p. 392). Payne et al. (2007, p. 588) state the link without the hedge: *some*, *every*, *any*, and *no* "can function solely as determiners and therefore never permit a preceding determiner".

Yet *some* is attested after *the*: *when times are bad,* [*the some*] *will become the many*; *one of* [*the some who hope for a return to the good old days*].[13] With *the* as determiner, a fused *some* can only be a modifier-head, and that's the Mod–Head Payne et al.'s "never" excludes. *CGEL*'s licence is hedged, and it records exceptions of both kinds itself. *Both*, which "cannot occur in internal modifier function", heads a nominal after *the* in *the both of us* (p. 377). *Every* and *various* function as modifiers after a determiner (*her every move*, *the various options*) but don't head a nominal there: "*Every* is again excluded, and so too this time is *various*" (p. 416).

So the link between the two uses is a default, not a condition. A determinative that functions as modifier after a determiner can usually head a nominal after one too, but the exceptions run both ways, and both analyses list the determinatives that can. Ordinary Head states the list as a permission, as it states the list of determinatives that stand alone (Section 3). Both also need *CGEL*'s observation that, cardinals apart, these determinatives are "hardly admissible" after a determiner unless the NP has a post-head modifier, as in *these few here* and *the many who did* (p. 416). That holds where *few* and *many* pick out part of a set given in the context. Read as 'few people' or 'many people', they stand alone after *the*, as *the rich* does.[14]

The some who also tells against a silent noun (Section 2). In *the some* [N] *who say it*, a silent noun would make *some* a modifier after *the*, which Payne et al. exclude (p. 588), and the overt sequence

[13] COCA: *Foreign Affairs*, 1999; iWeb: sspnet.org. COCA has five clear lines across searches for `the some`, `the some who`, and `the some of us who`; the other hits on the first display page of `the some` are typos for *same*, the adverb *some* 'approximately', titles, and garbled text. iWeb has 10 hits for `the some who`, most with no earlier *some* in view, so they aren't quotations of the word.

[14] A *Denver Post* sports writer quotes the Marine Corps slogan *The few. The proud. The Marines.*, which puts *the few* beside an adjective of the *rich* type, and then fills the same slots with adjectives: *The multitudinous. The shameless. The media.* (25 January 1999, from COCA). Spock's *the needs of the many outweigh the needs of the few* has both determinatives, and Kirk's reversal, *the needs of the one outweigh the needs of the many*, adds a cardinal (Littmann, 2016, pp. 128, 134).

doesn't turn up: of 53 iWeb hits for *the some people*, none of the 50 displayed has that reading. The silent noun would license silently what's excluded overtly.

The determiners these heads take follow the word too. With an adjective before independent *few*, the determiner is *the* in 192 of 321 COCA lines, and a demonstrative (*those chosen few*), a genitive (*Hollywood's chosen few*), *some*, *we*, or *us* in 35; nearly all the rest have *a*, which belongs to the DP, as argued below.[15] All of these are also determiners in NPs headed by plural nouns. The adjectives of the *rich* type take *the* or a genitive (*the world's poor*, *our elderly*), though *CGEL* says they're "determined by the definite article" and adds that "we couldn't even substitute a demonstrative: **these very poor*" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 417).[16] Nor does the category fix the range. Among adjectives, *blue* heads a nominal with no determiner (*I like* [*blue*]), *second* heads one after *a* (*I didn't want* [*a second*]), and *bigger* can't (**a bigger*) (pp. 416–417). Both analyses state the range word by word, or type by type.

What ordinary Head adds is one structure for every use of *few*: *few would dare*, *few of them*, *the few*, and *the lucky few*. In each, *few* heads the nominal, and a determiner, when there's one, is the NP's own. Fusion gives the first two Det–Head and the last two Mod–Head, so the same word heading the same kind of NP gets a different pair of functions depending on whether a determiner precedes it.

Which adjectives can head a nominal is a list on both analyses. *CGEL* gives types: superlatives and definite comparatives (*the tallest*, *the elder*); ordinals (*the second*); colour, provenance, and composition (*I like* [*blue*]); age and size (*I prefer* [*old*]); and the special interpretations of *the rich* and *the immoral* (pp. 416–417).[17] It excludes **the advancing* (p. 415), **a bigger*, and **the main* (p. 416). *Main* is attributive-only (p. 558), so modifier is its only function, and its exclusion is *CGEL*'s evidence that "the possibility of fusion with the head must in the last resort be stated in syntactic terms" (p. 416). Ordinary Head states the same list, as permissions to head a nominal. Generality is also *CGEL*'s argument against traditional grammar, which calls *several* a pronoun in [*several*] *look quite promising* and treats *the larger* as elliptical. Against that split, *CGEL* holds that "a unitary treatment is to be preferred on grounds of simplicity and generality" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 419),

[15] COCA, searched by hand for *lucky*, *chosen*, *fortunate*, *remaining*, and *priveledged* (sic) before *few*: 607 tokens, 368 lines inspected, 321 with no following noun. Of the 321, 192 have *the*, 90 *a* alone, 25 a demonstrative, 6 a genitive, 2 *some*, and 2 *we* or *us*; one is a name, and three have nothing before the adjective (a headline, a fragment, and a web post). With a preposition directly before the adjective, COCA has only headlines and blog posts (*Asylum for* [*Lucky Few*], *New York Times*, 1991). Web and Indian English differ: iWeb has 92 such tokens, 66 of them *select few*, often before a noun (*teleconverters only work with* [*select few*] *lenses*), and 17 of NOW's 22 bare tokens of *only select few* are from Indian sources. So the gap holds for edited standard English, not for every variety.

[16] COCA, 18 October 2026, searched by hand for `[apps*] poor|rich|elderly`: of the 500 lines displayed, 19 have the adjective heading the NP after a genitive pronoun (*care for* [*their elderly*], *New York Times*, 1992), and 9 more quote "your tired, your poor". Of 57 lines with a full stop after the adjective, 41 are the construction (*employment for* [*their poor*], *New York Times*, 1996), two of them with *rich* (*he doesn't mean* [*our rich*], reason.com, 2012). Demonstratives weren't searched.

[17] *CGEL* treats one more case elsewhere. *Above* is "primarily a preposition", but belongs by conversion to the adjective category in the sense of location in the discourse, and the adjective is a fused modifier-head in *Her conclusion is the same as* [*the above*] (p. 1555). *CGEL*'s own prose uses it freely (*All the above have transitive uses*, *Some of the above are verbs as well as nouns*, p. 1690). Like the types listed, it heads the nominal on both analyses. *CGEL* adds that *below* has no such use and "belongs only to the preposition category" (pp. 1555–1556), but COCA has both uses: before a noun in 185 of 197 lines of *the below* with a following noun (*are given in* [*the below table*], *Education*, 2011), and heading a nominal in 18 of 55 lines of *the below* before a full stop or after *of* (*is not either of* [*the below*], *Popular Mechanics*, 2014).

and fusion provides one. Ordinary Head keeps the gain with a single function: each word heads its nominal. Fusion gives the two words different pairs, Det–Head and Mod–Head.

Case shows no modifier function either. *CGEL*'s argument from the genitive concerns the determiner function (p. 420), and it states no case requirement for modifiers, so the check here is this paper's own: whether the genitive divides the fused modifier-heads as it divides the determiner-heads (Section 3). It does. *The latter's* and *the former's* are frequent, *the poor's* occurs in edited prose ([*the poor's*] *material well-being has improved*, *Newsweek*, 2010), *the rich's* only on the web, and *few* after a determiner almost never.[18] In these lines too, the division follows the word.

Mod–Head is also where the advantage Section 3 conceded to fusion has to be weighed. A bare determinative takes no pre-head adjective outside a few exclamations, taken up below (**Lucky few escaped*),[19] and fusion derives the gap from adjacency: with *few* as Det–Head, *lucky* would have to precede the determiner. After *the*, *few* is Mod–Head and *lucky* modifies the nominal it heads. Ordinary Head states a condition: a determinative heading a nominal takes a pre-head adjective only when the NP has a determiner.

A lucky few looks like an exception for both. Of the 321 COCA lines with an adjective before independent *few*, 90 have *a* as the only word before the adjective, and where a verb agrees with the phrase, it's plural: [*a lucky few*] *were sent far and wide to schools in other counties and states* (*Washington Post*, 2015). The adjective can be a phrase (*A very lucky few*, CNN, 2005). *CGEL* has two analyses that could apply. In one, *a few* is a complex determinative whose internal structure is "sui generis", admitting *very*, *good*, and *fair*, and it's put among the lexical determinatives "as with the cardinal numerals" (p. 392). In the other, *a* begins a sequence such as *a further* or *a good*, which takes a plural head if a numeral or *few* quantifies it, as in [*A further few volunteers*] *were needed* (p. 353), and in *a marvellous hundred days* "*a* is determiner and quite independent of *hundred*" (p. 385 n. 26).

Neither analysis separates fusion from ordinary Head. If *a* is the determiner, *few* follows a determiner, as in *the lucky few*, and the adjective comes after it, so adjacency is undisturbed and ordinary Head's condition is met. If *a* belongs to the determinative, so does the adjective, which then comes before no head at all. Either way the grammar needs a statement, a list of the sequences with *a* that take a plural head or a slot inside the determinative, and the statement is the same on both analyses.

I take the second, in a form that gives *a good few* one analysis where *CGEL*'s two treatments would give it two (pp. 353, 392). In *a hundred days*, *CGEL* says that *a*, which replaces *one*, "must be considered as an integral part of the numeral, and not as an independent determiner", since "the whole NP is clearly plural, not singular, as it would be if *a* were the determiner" (p. 385). Reynolds (2026, pp. 7, 10) argues that numerals above 99 are phrases, with the factor (*one* in *one thousand*) a modifier

[18] One COCA search for *the latter*, *the former*, *the other*, *the poor*, and *the rich* followed by *'s* displayed 500 lines, probably a cap (498 pasted). In those lines the genitives number 149 for *the latter*, 31 for *the former*, 8 for *the poor* (five in magazines and academic writing), and 3 for *the rich* (all web or blog). *CGEL* has one in its own prose: in its account of the traditional definition, a preposition "expresses the latter's relation to another word" (p. 598). *The other* has 253, set aside because its plural *others* leaves a noun analysis open. `the few/many 's` gave no genitive, and `few 's` one after a determiner, [*the first few's*] *salty freshness* (*Ploughshares*, 1996, fiction). A cardinal after a determiner takes the genitive freely: `those|the two 's` gives it in 21 of 34 lines, ten of them in edited prose ([*the two's*] *relationship gets worse the longer Rosberg leads the championship*, *New York Post*, 2016).

[19] *Precious few would dare* isn't an exception. For *precious* in *They had precious little money*, Matthews (2014, p. 102) offers the predicative use as the crucial evidence that it's an adverb (*The money they had left was precious little*), and the same test works for *few* (*Volunteers were precious few*). So *precious* is a modifier in the DP, as *very* is in *very few*, not in the nominal.

of the magnitude word, and that other modifiers can come between them (*one whole thousand*). On that analysis, *a few* is a DP headed by *few*, with *a* as a modifier, and *a very few*, *a good few*, *a further few*, and *a lucky few* are the same DP with a modifier after *a* (Figure 3).[20] Before a noun the DP is the determiner (*a lucky few students*). On its own it heads the nominal, or for fusion is a Det–Head. *Quite* modifies it in *quite a few* (p. 392), and the NP is plural, as *a hundred days* is, because *a* isn't its determiner. That the adjective comes only after *a*, as *whole* comes after the factor in *one whole thousand*, is stated on both analyses. So *a lucky few* no longer counts against either, and fusion's derivation of **Lucky few escaped* stands.

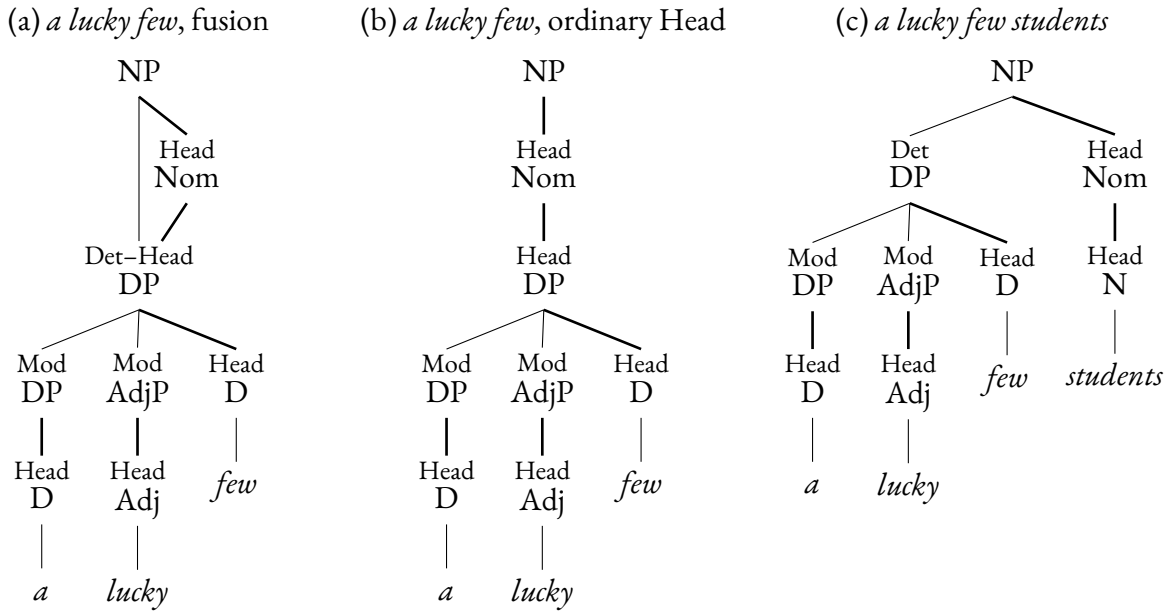


Figure 3: *A lucky few* under fusion (a) and ordinary Head (b), and *a lucky few students* (c), on the analysis adopted here. *A* and *lucky* are modifiers in the DP headed by *few*, as *one* and *whole* are to *thousand* in *one whole thousand*, so the adjective is neither before the determiner nor in the nominal.

For Payne et al. (2007, p. 584), a condition of this kind is "precisely the kind of stipulation which is not required when the determiner and head functions are fused". They say it of an analysis of the compounds with a silent head, but it applies to ordinary Head's condition as well. Whether the grammar needs such a statement anyway turns on the other heads that take no determiner in their primary use, pronouns and proper names. *CGEL*'s treatment of them separates three questions: whether such a head takes a pre-head dependent at all, whether it takes a non-restrictive adjective, and whether a restrictive one needs a determiner.

On the first, the grammar already makes a statement of this kind, for pronouns. *CGEL* makes it "a defining property of pronouns" that "they do not permit determiners" (p. 429), and they "do not

[20] The slot is open. Besides *CGEL*'s *a good few* and *a fair few* (p. 392), COCA has at least 28 adjectives in it before a plural noun, in at least 123 tokens ([*a mere few*] *feet*, [*a paltry few*] *pages*, [*a harrowing few*] *quarters*). For *a great many*, *CGEL* allows *great* or *good* and says that "one or other of these adjectives is required" (p. 394), but COCA has ten others in that slot, one token each, as in *when a shrinking few do very well and* [*a growing many*] *barely make it* (NPR, 2013). *A few* is positive where *few* is negative (pp. 393–394), which I take to be a convention of the combination, as the minimizer reading of *a bit* is in *They didn't enjoy it* [*a bit*] (pp. 549–550).

normally allow internal pre-head dependents" (**Extravagant he bought a new car*, p. 430). They take some dependents after the head, as in *you who worked on both the projects* (p. 429). The compound determinatives split the same way (*nothing sensible*, *everything in the collection*), and for them *CGEL* derives the gap from fusion: "Because determiner and head are fused it is not possible for these forms to take internal pre-head dependents" (p. 423). A pronoun has no determiner function to derive it from.

So the grammar already states, without deriving it, that one kind of head with no determiner normally takes no pre-head dependent. Ordinary Head's condition isn't that statement, though. Since *CGEL* defines pronouns as taking no determiner, it can state their restriction without mentioning one. Pronouns with a determiner, as in *the real me*, come up below. A determinative takes an adjective only after a determiner, so ordinary Head's condition has to mention one. Fusion's derivation saves that statement, but not a kind of statement the grammar would otherwise lack.

The second question favours ordinary Head, though not by much. Names take a few non-restrictive adjectives with no determiner (*poor Henry*, *Young Isaac Newton went off to Cambridge*; pp. 520–521), and the core personal pronouns take *lucky*, *poor*, and *silly* (*Lucky you!*, *poor old me*; p. 430). Simple determinatives don't seem to (**Lucky few!*, **Poor many!*). But two compounds are attested in the pronouns' exclamation, each just after the same exclamation with a name or a pronoun: *Poor Val. Poor everybody.* (*New Yorker*, 2005), *Lucky you. Lucky everyone.* (*Everwood*, 2004).[21]

For *CGEL*, *everybody* and *everyone* are fused determiner-heads, so an internal pre-head dependent is "not possible" for them (p. 423). Fusion can call them nouns by conversion here, like *a nobody* (p. 423 n. 43), though they keep the compounds' universal meaning and take no determiner. It can list them as an exception, as *CGEL* does for pronouns, or take the adjective as a modifier of the whole NP, though that separates them from *Lucky you!*, which *CGEL* counts among internal pre-head dependents (p. 430). On any of these, adjacency no longer derives the gap for them. Ordinary Head adds them to *CGEL*'s exception, "a few adjectives such as *lucky*, *poor*, *silly* with the core personal pronouns". Either way the compounds need a listed exception, and only on fusion does it go against a principle.

The third question is where pronouns and names look most like determinatives, but the likeness comes from countability. A restrictive adjective after a determiner is routine with personal pronouns: COCA has 350 tokens of *the real me*. In this use the pronoun heads a singular NP, which takes a third-person singular verb (*The real you is still alive back on Earth*, *Analog*, 2019).[22] *CGEL* would presumably call the word a common noun here, as it calls *he* and *she* in *Is it a he or a she?* (p. 429 n. 46),

[21] COCA, 18 October 2026, searched by hand for `poor|lucky|silly everybody|everyone|somebody|someone`: 28 lines. Of the rest, 19 have *lucky* before a clause (*You're lucky someone called it in*), four are predicative (*How poor everyone had been*), one has a determiner (*I made him the lucky someone*), and two are a list and a depictive. No line has *somebody* or *someone* in the use. NOW and iWeb have six more, four of them closing a series after a name or noun (*Poor Amy. Poor Deb.* [*Poor everyone*]., TV Fanatic, 2016) and two on their own, a remark reported in the *University of Chicago Chronicle* (2021) and the title of a 2022 Carrie Underwood song, *Poor Everybody Else*.

[22] COCA, 15 October 2026, searches run by hand. Of the 14 lines for `the real you [be]`, ten have *the real you* as subject, all with *is* or *'s* and none with *are*. On one display page of `the real you`, 193 of the 198 lines have the restrictive use.

though the reflexive suggests a secondary use of the pronoun.[23] On either view the head is singular and count, and an NP with a singular count head needs a determiner, with or without a modifier.

Names are the same. In *The young Isaac Newton showed no signs of genius*, *young* restricts a secondary use in which the name denotes a set of manifestations, and in such uses "determiners are thus selected in the ordinary way" (pp. 520–521). A singular name in that use needs a determiner for the reason a singular count noun generally does. A plural head needs none, and takes a restrictive adjective without one, a plural name included (*Lucky survivors were airlifted out*, *Young Kennedys still go into politics*). So nothing that holds for names or for *the real me* predicts **Remaining few were the hangers-on* beside *The remaining few were the hangers-on* (*Christian Century*, 1998). Fusion's adjacency does.

The comparison cuts both ways, then. On the first question, *CGEL* already states that pronouns normally take no pre-head dependent, so ordinary Head's condition is a further statement of a kind the grammar already contains. On the second, two compounds take an adjective in the pronouns' exclamation, which adjacency rules out. On the third, the facts with a determiner follow from number and countability and give ordinary Head nothing. The pre-head adjective remains the one trace of the determiner function (Section 3), but its derivation saves less than Payne et al. suggest.

Nothing in the form of Mod–Head expressions, then, shows the modifier function. Which determinatives take an external determiner, which determiners they take, which adjectives head a nominal, and which heads take the genitive all follow the word, and both analyses list them. Fusion derives the absence of an adjective before a bare determinative, where ordinary Head states it, and for *Poor everybody!* both need an exception.

5 *Once*, *twice*, AND *thrice*

Payne et al. (2007) built their case for fusion on *once*, *twice*, and *thrice*. They distinguish five uses of *once*: numerical (*I will only say this to you once*), singulative (*Not once have I seen anything like this*), past (*I was once a teenage werewolf*), term of office (*the once mayor of New York*), and sequential, which they analyse as a preposition like *after*, with no fusion (pp. 584, 592, 594). *Twice* and *thrice* have the numerical and term-of-office uses, and a multiplier use (pp. 594–596).

Much of their argument concerns category. Against an adverb analysis, numerical *once* takes determiners and relative clauses, freely and not only in idioms (*four times for every once that the large pulley goes round*, p. 586 and n. 28), and it can function as subject (*Once is enough*, p. 587). Against the noun analysis of some dictionaries (p. 587), it takes the pre-head modifiers of *one*: *at least once* beside *at least one time*, *more than once* beside *more than one time* (p. 589). It's a determinative, and on ordinary Head it heads the nominal of its NP, so what's in question is again only the second function.

They take the form of the word to show that function too. In *someone* and the other compound determinatives "the morphological compounding in this case reflects the fusion of two syntactic functions", and *once* is "similarly" a compound, of a determinative base *on·* and a noun base *·ce* 'time' (pp. 587–588). But simple *some* and *few* are fused with no compounding, and Payne et al.'s own note takes *·ce* to be a reanalysed genitive ending (p. 588 n. 30), and Wu (2021, p. 89) finds their noun

[23] The reflexive keeps the pronoun's person (*The 12-year-old me is kicking myself*), as a common noun's doesn't (**Daddy is enjoying myself*), except that a stage of the speaker contrasted with another can take third-person forms (Halm, 2021, pp. 19, 29–30).

base "far from convincing". What the two bases mirror is the word's meaning, a quantifier with a sort, as in the compounds (Section 3), and both analyses give *once* that meaning.

The first thing fusion is said to explain is why *once* occurs both with and without a determiner, which a singular count noun doesn't. Numerical *one* functions as determiner (*one time*) and as modifier after a determiner (*this one time*), so *once* is a fused determiner-head on its own and a fused modifier-head after *this* (p. 588). That's the link between the two uses that Section 4 examined for *few*, a default with exceptions both ways. Ordinary Head states it as a permission: *once* may head a nominal with or without a determiner.

The second is the adjective. Since the fused *once* is also the determiner, **last once* is excluded "for the same reason as" **last one time*, while *this last once* is fine (p. 589). One of their *JL* referees judged *this last once* ungrammatical, and they allow that speakers may vary (p. 586 n. 26). COCA, NOW, and iWeb have neither *this last once* nor *the last once*, but they have the pattern with *twice*, their (33b) (p. 595), as in [*The last twice*] *I checked my 71 GT I got 29 to the gallon* (mgexp.com).[24] So the adjective after a determiner is attested, though not with *once*. The gap before a bare *once* is the one Section 4 weighed for *few*.[25] Fusion derives it from adjacency, and ordinary Head excludes it by its condition on pre-head adjectives, a further statement of a kind the grammar already contains. Their further example, *(*this*) *once last* with a silent head after *last* (p. 589), separates fusion from a silent head, not from ordinary Head.

Larger phrases go the same way. A DP such as *at least once* or *more than once*, or a PP such as *up to twice*, functions for Payne et al. as fused determiner-head (pp. 589–590 and n. 31), and after a determiner as fused modifier-head (*not the more than once which would have been permitted*, pp. 590–591). Ordinary Head puts each in the head function alone. A fused determiner-head is also head of the nominal, so the PP *up to twice* heads a nominal on both analyses. In *once more*, *more* is a post-head modifier on both, as in *something more* (p. 591).

Singulative and past *once* take no determiner and no attributive adjective, though they take relative clauses (*Not once that I can think of*, *Once when the opera Aida was about to be performed*) (p. 592). Payne et al. trace both gaps to singulative *one*, which "always functions as a determiner, not as a modifier" (p. 592). For the determiner, that's the default of Section 4 again, which both analyses follow here. For the adjective, fusion derives the gap from adjacency and ordinary Head from its condition, the trade already counted for *few*.

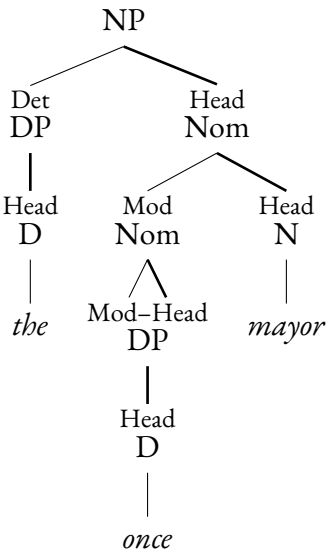
Term-of-office *once* functions as attributive modifier (*the once mayor*), as does *twice* in *the twice president*, which many speakers find unnatural (pp. 593, 595). Both analyses have to state that the use is largely confined to names of offices (**my once job as a glass-blower*, pp. 585, 593). For Payne et al., *once* here "will act as a fused modifier-head forming a nominal rather than forming a full NP" (p. 593),

[24] Searched by hand on 18 October 2026. With `this last.[md*] once`, *last* tagged as an ordinal, COCA and NOW have no hits, and the plain string `this last once` gives COCA nothing and NOW and iWeb only the verb *last* (*How long does this last once the oils are mixed?*) and a slip for *this last one*; `this last twice` has no hits in any of the three. With the plain string `the last once`, no line in the three corpora clearly has *once* heading a nominal: most are slips for *one* or *ounce*, or have *once* as an adverb or the sequential preposition. NOW has 290 tokens of *the last twice*, and all 180 of its displayed lines have *twice* heading the NP, 176 of them from British or Irish sources, most of them racing reports (*He's gone well* [*the last twice*], *Racing Post*, 2026). iWeb has 28 such lines of 39, and COCA none.

[25] In 97 COCA lines of *a*, a word that can be tagged as an adjective, and *once* or *twice*, none has an adjective before *once* or *twice* heading a nominal after *a*, as in *a lucky few*. The adjective comes before *once* only in the noun *once-over* (*a quick once-over*, 17 lines) and in *once-in-a-lifetime* (3). In the rest, *once* or *twice* is outside the NP (*I saw* [*a psychic*] *once*). Nothing here calls for the statement that *a lucky few* needs on both analyses.

so the attribute is a nominal whose head is also its modifier. On ordinary Head the determinative *once* simply functions as modifier in the nominal *once mayor*, as *two* does in *the two books*. That's one function where fusion has two, and one nominal fewer (Figure 4), though the lexical statement is no shorter.

(a) *the once mayor*, fusion



(b) *the once mayor*, ordinary Head

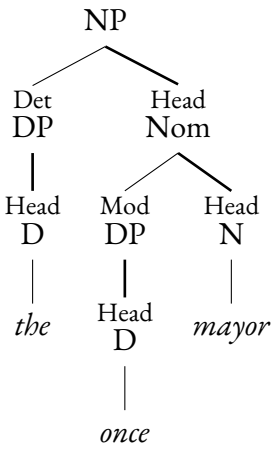


Figure 4: Term-of-office *once* under fusion (a) and ordinary Head (b). Payne et al. don't draw (a); it follows their description of *once* as "a fused modifier-head forming a nominal" that functions as attributive modifier (pp. 593, 595). In (b) the DP is a modifier in the nominal and nothing else, as *two* is in *the two books*.

The rest of their case doesn't bear on the second function. Multiplier *twice* (*twice the amount*) functions as predeterminer modifier, where the NP *two times* can replace it (p. 596), and inside it's the word of the numerical use, so the question of its functions is the one already examined. In *once a week once* is head (p. 596 n. 40), on both analyses. Their non-standard uses (pp. 596–597) turn on category and on *once* heading a nominal, which the analyses share: in ¦*at once or another*, *or another* reaches the base *on·*, as in *somebody or another*, and ¦*the once and only time* coordinates the nominal *once* with *only time*. In ¦*the twice the amount*, ordinary Head has *twice* heading the nominal where Payne et al. have a fused modifier-head (p. 597), as in *just the twice* (p. 595).

No property of form in this paradigm varies with the second function rather than with the word,[26] so on the criterion of Section 2 the paradigm fusion was developed on is neutral between the analyses. Where their structures differ, in the term-of-office use, ordinary Head has the fewer functions.

[26] The genitive, which divides the fused determiner-heads word by word (Section 3), is absent from all the uses: COCA, NOW, and iWeb have no genitive of *once*, *twice*, or *thrice*. Ordinary Head adds the three words to its list of gaps. Fusion predicts the gap, unless it lets a compound's nominal base carry the genitive, as in *everyone's* (Section 3), and then *·ce* needs an exception.

6 What each analysis states

Sections 3 and 4 compared the two analyses construction by construction. Table 1 puts the results together. Both columns use *CGEL*'s categories and the same lexical facts, so what the table compares is how each analysis has to state them. The full fragment, with the permissions and Head relations of each analysis, is in the online supplement.

Table 1: What fusion and ordinary Head state for determinatives standing alone and for adjectives heading a nominal. Above the line, the two analyses state the same content, each in its own terms; below it, they differ.

	Fusion (*CGEL*)	Ordinary Head
Determinatives that stand alone (*some*; *every* only rarely)	A list of the words that allow Det–Head	The same list, as permissions to head a nominal with no determiner
The forms *none* and *mine*	Dependent form as determiner, independent form as head (p. 410)	The same
Determinatives that head a nominal after a determiner (*the few*)	A default from the modifier use, with exceptions both ways: head but not modifier (*some*, *both*), modifier but not head (*every*, *various*)	The same default and exceptions, as permissions
A post-head modifier in that use, cardinals apart (*the many who did*)	Normally needed (p. 416)	The same condition
Determiners these heads take	Word by word: a plural noun's range for *few* (*those chosen few*); for adjectives, *the* or a genitive with *rich* (p. 417), none with *blue*	The same
A few and its expansions (*a lucky few*)	A slot for a modifier after *a* in the DP headed by *few* (Section 4), or a list of sequences with *a* that take a plural head (p. 353)	The same
Adjectives that head a nominal	*CGEL*'s types, with exclusions such as **the main* (pp. 415–417)	The same list, as permissions
Genitive on a determinative standing alone	The gap predicted for all, with a list of exceptions (*either's*, *neither's*, *each's*; compounds such as *everyone's*, unless their nominal base carries it)	The genitive expected, with a list of gaps (*all*, *many*, *few*, *some*; *once*, *twice*, *thrice*)
Change of category on the head path	Where a DP or AdjP heads a nominal, or a PP (*up to twice*, Payne et al., p. 589 n. 31)	The same
Once, *twice*, and *thrice*	Numerical uses fused like *one*: Det–Head on their own, Mod–Head after a determiner; singulative and past uses Det–Head only (Payne et al., pp. 588, 592); term of office largely confined to names of offices (p. 593); sequential use not fused (a preposition, p. 594)	The same uses, as permissions: numerical uses head a nominal with or without a determiner, singulative and past uses only without one; the same range for term of office; sequential use as for fusion
A second function for the head of the nominal	Determiner for a determinative with no determiner before it; modifier for one after a determiner, and for adjectives and nouns such as *nylon*; term-of-office *once* a nominal of its own as attribute (Payne et al., p. 593)	None outside fused relatives, so *few* heads its nominal in the same way in *few would dare*, *few of them*, *the few*, and *the lucky few*; term-of-office *once* a modifier, as *two* is in *the two books*
A pre-head adjective with no determiner (**Lucky few escaped*)	Excluded by adjacency, as for the compounds (p. 423), but *Poor everybody!* needs an exception (Section 4)	Excluded by a condition: only after a determiner. *CGEL* states a restriction of this kind for pronouns (p. 430), and *everybody* and *everyone* join their exception

Above the line, the content is shared. The lists, defaults, and conditions follow the word, as Sections 3 and 4 found, and each analysis phrases them in its own terms: fusion as licences for a fused function, ordinary Head as permissions to head a nominal.

Below the line is the trade. Fusion gives the head of the nominal a second function and derives from it the absence of a pre-head adjective before a bare determinative, with an exception for *Poor everybody!*. Ordinary Head has no second function and states the condition instead, a statement of the kind *CGEL* already makes for pronouns (p. 430; Section 4). It gains generality: *few* heading the same kind of NP gets one structure, where fusion gives it one pair of functions with no determiner and another after one. That's the kind of gain *CGEL* claims for fusion against traditional grammar (p. 419; Section 4).

The two departures Payne et al. (2007, pp. 570–571) distinguish fall differently too. Fusion puts both on one constituent wherever a DP, AdjP, or PP is a fused head, since that phrase has two functions and is also where the category changes. Ordinary Head never puts both on one constituent. Its constituents with two functions are in fused relatives, where the fused phrase and its parent must project the same lexical category (p. 574), so no category changes there. In a bare fused relative such as *I'll take* [*whichever he gave me*], the two meet in one NP at different nodes: the DP heads the nominal, and the NP is head and prenucleus at once (Section 7, Figure 6).

On the criterion of Section 2, a property of form that varied with the determiner or modifier function and not with the word would count for fusion. Form there means the shape of words, order, and the dependents and determiners a word takes. For the determiner function, the test compares one word with and without it. *CGEL* gives determinatives no use as a pure head, so the comparison is between a determinative standing alone and the same word after a determiner, and it changes two things at once: the word loses its determiner function, and a determiner precedes it. A fact that separates the two uses is predicted by fusion, and also by any condition that mentions a determiner. The modifier function has no such contrast, and the test is the one Section 4 applied: a form found only with the function, or a fact of order that only a modifier relation predicts. Shape, dependents, the determiners taken, and the genitive show nothing of either kind (Sections 3 and 4).

The pre-head adjective does, and it counts for fusion. *Few* takes none standing alone in edited prose, and takes one after *the*, and fusion derives the difference from adjacency, where ordinary Head states a condition. *A lucky few* isn't an exception on either analysis of *a* (Section 4). *Poor everybody!* is, as *Lucky you!* is for *CGEL*'s statement about pronouns. So the evidence for the determiner function is one fact with one exception, and against it are the generality ordinary Head gains for *few* and the constituent with two parents that fusion gives every NP headed by a bare determinative. I take the balance to favour ordinary Head, though not to force it. What would reverse it is a second fact of the adjective's kind: a form a determinative has only when it stands alone, which its meaning and countability don't explain.

The saving is in where fusion applies, not in whether the grammar has it. Ordinary Head keeps constituents with two functions for fused relatives, so it removes them from noun phrases without a relative clause, not from the grammar. What it gains there is one head relation for each word across its uses, and constituents with two parents confined to the one construction where form shows the second function. Section 7 finds such facts in fused relatives.

7 Fused relatives: where the second function shows

Payne et al. (2007, p. 571) list the dependents that fusion involves in English as "determiner, modifier and, in fused relative clauses, subject or prenucleus". Sections 3 and 4 found one fact of form that shows a second function in Det–Head expressions, the missing adjective, and none in Mod–Head ones. Fused relatives are the remaining test. *CGEL* brings fusion to them in so many words: "we invoke the same concept of functional fusion in our analysis of fused relatives" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1073).[27]

(4) a. *I spent* [*whatever he gave me*]. (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1068)
b. [*Whoever told you that*] *can't have read the report carefully.* (p. 1076)
c. *I'll go* [*wherever you go*]. (p. 1068)

In (4a), *whatever* is head of the object NP and prenucleus of the relative clause, with a gap after *gave me* (Huddleston and Pullum, 2002, p. 1073; Figure 5a). In (4b), *whoever* is head of the subject NP and also the subject of *told you that*, which Payne et al. (2007, 579 n. 16) call "fused head-subject". The criterion asks whether the function inside the relative clause shows in form.

Ordinary Head is available here too. *Whomever I see* could be an NP headed by *whomever*, with a bare relative as modifier in its nominal, just as *person* heads *the person I see*. Put in *CGEL*'s terms, it's the analysis Bresnan and Grimshaw (1978) proposed: the relativized phrase heads the whole NP, and "there is no fronted element in the relative clause" (Payne et al., 2007, p. 578). It needs nothing beyond ordinary Head and a kind of relative clause the grammar already has, and I'll call it the head analysis (Figure 5b).

[27] Transparent free relatives, as in *He made* [*what may appear to be a radically new proposal*] (Grosu, 2003, p. 248), raise different questions and are set aside here (Grosu, 2003, 2016).

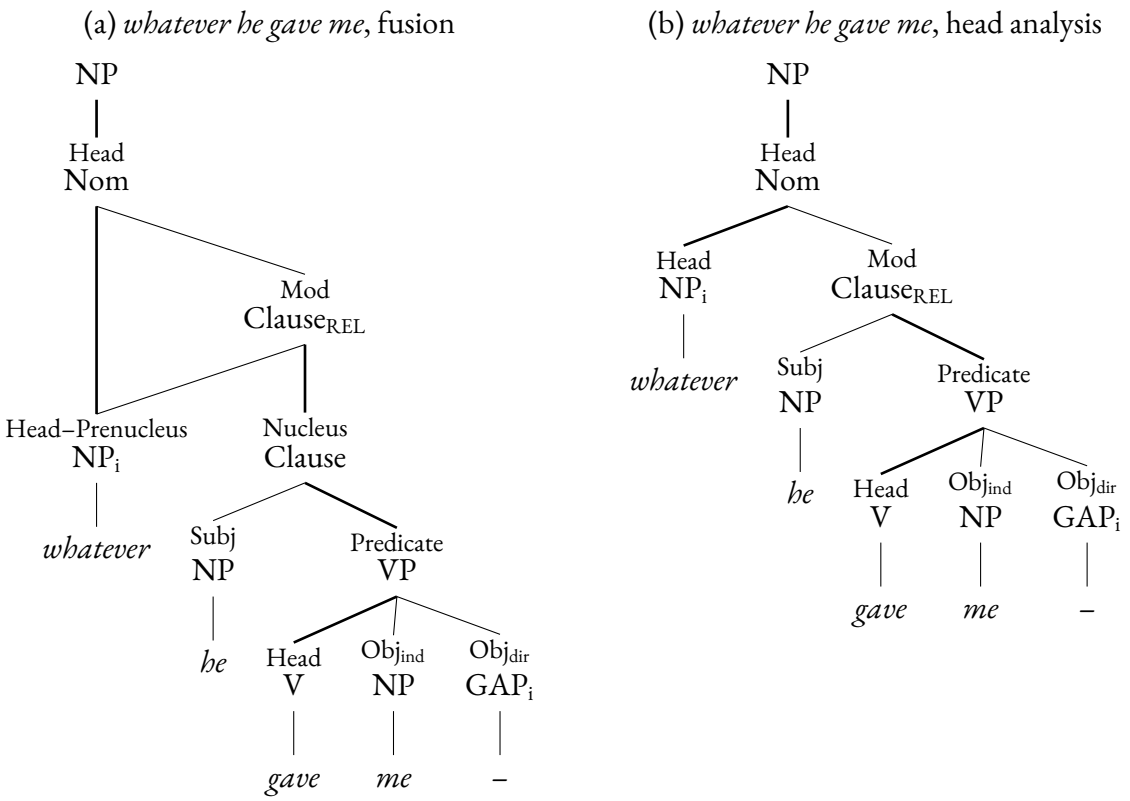


Figure 5: A fused relative under fusion (a), following *CGEL*'s tree for *what she wrote* (p. 1073), and under the head analysis (b). In (a) the NP *whatever* has two parents, the nominal it heads and the relative clause in which it's the prenucleus, linked to the gap. In (b) the NP heads the nominal, outside the bare relative clause that is its modifier. Thick lines join heads to their parents, the nucleus counting as head of the relative clause. Other NPs are shown without their structure, as in *CGEL*'s tree.

Much comes out the same. The evidence that fused relatives are NPs holds on either: agreement, subject–auxiliary inversion, no extraposition, no fronted preposition, and the functions of NPs (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1068–1070). So does what the literature calls matching, in which the relativized phrase's category suits "categorial selection both in the matrix clause and in the relative clause" (van Riemsdijk, 2006, p. 349). Bresnan and Grimshaw (1978, pp. 336–338) derive the match with the matrix from headedness, since a phrase has the category of its head, and on either analysis the match with the gap comes from the relative clause. So category matching doesn't separate the two analyses. Three other properties do.

First, in standard English bare relatives can't relativize their subject. *CGEL* contrasts [*The car I took*] *was Ed's* with *[*The car hit us*] *was Ed's*, and the restriction holds whatever the head: ![*Anyone wants this*] *can have it* is non-standard (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1055).[28] *Anyone* is a compound determinative, and it heads its NP whether it's an ordinary Head (Section 3) or a fused determiner-head. So that example has the head analysis's structure, a head with a bare relative, and it fails. Holding the frame constant gives the same contrast with a fused relative:

[28] The mark ! is *CGEL*'s, for a form it treats as non-standard.

(5) a. *I will do business with* [*whichever of them comes up with the cash*]. (Payne et al., 2007, 579 n. 16)
b. !*I will do business with* [*any of them comes up with the cash*].
c. *I will do business with* [*whichever of them you recommend*].
d. *I will do business with* [*any of them you recommend*].

With an object gap, *any of them* takes a bare relative freely (5d), so only the relativized subject separates (5a) from (5b). On the fused analysis, *whichever of them* is itself the subject of *comes up with the cash*.[29] The clause has no subject gap, and the restriction doesn't apply. The head analysis has to give relative words a licence that the restriction withholds from every other head.

Second, ordinary heads take infinitival relatives without a relative word, as in *something interesting* (*for us*) *to read* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 1067), but a fused relative can't be infinitival: **I can't afford* [*what to buy*] (p. 1073). Kim (2017, pp. 364, 378) also stars *He is still wearing* [*what to wear to bed*] and *Tom will do* [*whatever to satisfy her*].

The head analysis predicts *what to buy* to be as good as *something to buy*. On the fused analysis, *what* would be the relative phrase of an infinitival relative clause, and there "the relative phrase must consist of preposition + NP" (p. 1067), as in *the ideal person* [*in whom*] *to confide*. The fused element of an NP fused relative is an NP, so it never qualifies.[30]

Third, case. *CGEL* names case as the form in which a second function would show (pp. 420, 1073–1074), and for fused relatives with *who* and *whoever* it states the requirement: the pronoun "has to satisfy the case requirements of both the relative clause and the matrix clause" (p. 1073).

(6) a. [*Whoever is responsible for the damage*] *must pay for it.* (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 1073–1074)
b. *He will criticise* [*whomever she brings home*].
c. ?[*Whomever he marries*] *will have to be very tolerant.*
d. ?*She lunches with* [*whomever is going her way after morning classes*].

In (6c), the relative clause calls for accusative and the matrix for nominative. In (6d) it's the reverse. *CGEL* judges both "at best very questionable" (p. 1074).

On the head analysis as stated so far, *whomever* stands outside the relative clause, so its form should answer to the matrix alone. That was the analysis's attraction for matching: the head "would automatically bear the case of the whole NP" (Payne et al., 2007, p. 578). Bresnan and Grimshaw (1978) add an agreement condition between the head and the gap, and languages differ on whether

[29] On *CGEL*'s analysis, *whichever* is fused twice here. Inside its own NP it's a fused determiner-head (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 398), and that NP is fused head and subject in the relative construction, which Payne et al. count as "multiple instances of fused functions" (p. 579 n. 16). Bare *whichever* in *I'll take* [*whichever he gave me*] is fused twice in the same way, with head and prenucleus. Ordinary Head removes the inner fusion, which shows nothing in form (Section 3), and keeps the outer one, which does (Figure 6).

[30] *CGEL* finds "no evident explanation" for that restriction (p. 1067), and the argument takes it as stated. *CGEL* also says infinitival relatives with a relative phrase occur only as integrated relatives (p. 1067), which would exclude fused ones directly. The restriction on the relative phrase covers NP fused relatives without that statement. It doesn't cover a PP fused relative whose relative phrase is a preposition with an NP, as in *I'll work* [*in whichever city they want me to work*] (Payne et al., 2007, p. 575). That **I'll work* [*in whichever city to work*] is out too rests on the statement about integrated relatives.

case is among the features that must agree: the head takes the subordinate verb's case in Finnish but not in Old English (pp. 353, 373–374). With case included, the head analysis can make *whomever* answer to the clause too, but only by a further statement, where fusion gets the same result from the prenucleus. Without it, the head analysis predicts (6c) to be degraded but not (6d). There *whomever* is the object of *with*, where accusative is the formal choice (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, pp. 465–466). The question mark on (6d) shows the subject function inside the relative clause.

CGEL's two dialects for *whom* point the same way. When *who* is the subject of a clause embedded in a relative, as in %*those* [*whom*] *he thought were guilty*, Dialect A takes its case from that function, and Dialect B from its "prenuclear position preceding the subject of the relative clause" (Huddleston & Pullum, 2002, p. 467). Both rules look inside the relative clause, and the head analysis puts *whomever* outside it, so it needs the agreement statement here too.

Usage shows the same thing directly, as a preference. After a preposition the matrix function is the same in every token, so the head analysis predicts the same choice of form whatever follows. In COCA, *whoever* and *whomever* occur after a preposition 802 times before a pronoun subject, as in *with whomever they …*, and *whomever* has 395 of those (49%). They occur there 2,458 times before a verb, where the gap is the subject, as in *to whomever is …*, and *whomever* has 352 of those (14%).[31]

So the function inside the relative clause shows in the form. The matrix function shows too. Where a fused relative at the start of a sentence is the subject of the main clause, *whomever* has 8 of about 51 tokens with a non-subject gap ([*Whomever I chose for this experiment*] *should be close to the mean*, *Southern Review*, 2015) and 32 of about 2,100 with a subject gap.[32] So the form answers to both functions. *Whomever* is about half the tokens where both call for accusative (after a preposition, with a non-subject gap), under 2% where both call for nominative, and 14% and about 16% in the two clashes, one of which is (6c). Fusion predicts that a clash has no fully acceptable form, which is what *CGEL*'s question marks record; *CGEL* adds that *whoever* "would be preferable in both, but many would regard it as less than fully acceptable in formal style" (p. 1074). That clashes are attested all the same makes the double requirement a preference, so case favours fusion here rather than forcing it.[33]

CGEL drew this analogy itself. Its explanation of the missing genitive in **many's expenses* is that the form's "case should match both functions", and it points to "the discussion of case in fused relatives" (p. 420). Among fused determiner-heads, the genitive divides the words: *many's* is all but absent,

[31] COCA, searched by hand on 17 October 2026 with `[i*] who*ever [p*]` and `[i*] who*ever [v*]`. Tokens before *it* are left out, because *it* can be the subject of a clause whose gap is a predicative complement, as in *whoever it is*; of the 180 such tokens, *whomever* has 35. The verb list shows only its 1,000 most frequent types, so its counts are lower bounds. The archaic forms divide the same way: *whomsoever* and *whosoever* have 21 and 2 tokens before a pronoun, 12 and 30 before a verb. In ordinary relatives with a subject gap, *whom* is rare by comparison, with 390 tokens of `[nn*] whom [v*]` against 449,450 of `[nn*] who [v*]`, so most subject-gap tokens of *whomever* owe their form to something outside the relative clause. A check of about 200 lines of each form (18 October) found a non-subject gap in all but one *whomever* line before a pronoun other than *it*, and in 131 of the 148 such *whoever* lines. The other *whoever* lines have a predicative gap (*for whoever she is*), the subject of an embedded clause (*whoever you think is guilty*), or a fused relative that is the subject of a clause after *until* or *before* (*until whoever you're waiting for gets here*). Without them the share is about 52%.

[32] COCA, searched by hand on 18 October 2026 with `. whomever [p*]`, `. whoever [p*]`, `. whomever [v*]`, and `. whoever [v*]`. The *whomever* lines are all the hits (23 and 42); the *whoever* counts are estimated from 500-line samples of 644 and 2,606 hits. Lines in which the fused relative isn't the subject of the main clause are left out, most of them exhaustive conditionals (*Whoever you are, …*), which *CGEL* treats as interrogative clauses (p. 1072 n. 15).

[33] van Riemsdijk (2006, p. 357) finds that case matching concerns "the actual morpho-phonological shape of the case form": in German, where nominative and accusative *was* have the same form, a mismatch of the abstract cases passes. Which function's case wins a clash varies across languages (Payne et al., 2007, p. 578).

but *either's*, *each's*, and *everyone's* occur. That division follows the word, not the functions, which all these words share on *CGEL*'s analysis (Section 3), and *the poor's* puts the genitive on a fused modifier-head (Section 4). In fused relatives the word stays the same and the form follows the function inside the relative clause, as a preference. On the diagnostic *CGEL* itself chose, the two constructions come apart.

CGEL analyses some fused relatives as PPs, as in *I'll go* [*wherever you go*] (p. 1068), and Payne et al. (2007, p. 575) add AdjPs and AdvPs, as in *I'll be* [*however responsive they want me to be*]. The evidence above comes from NP fused relatives. In the other types case can't arise, since none of these phrases has case, but the first property can. In [*Whenever suits you*] *is fine*, *whenever* is the subject of *suits*, so on the head analysis *suits you* would be a bare relative with a subject gap.

These types also show that, on *CGEL*'s analysis, no other construction puts a relative clause inside such a phrase, since "standard relative clauses are modifiers only within Nom" (Payne et al., 2007, p. 575), and yet both analyses need one there. On fusion, it belongs to one construction across the four categories, in which the head of the phrase is also the clause's prenucleus. On the head analysis, the NP type has a relative clause in its nominal, and the other three a relative clause as modifier in a PP, AdjP, or AdvP. It can license all four as one construction too, so the four types don't separate the analyses, but that construction is again one whose head has licences no other head has.[34]

So the second function shows in form in three ways, two of them categorical and one graded. The head analysis can state each, but only by giving fused-relative words licences no other head has: subject relativization without a relative word, no infinitival form, and case agreement with a gap in a clause the word isn't part of. Fusion gets all three from the rules for relative clauses that have a relative phrase.[35] So fusion is favoured here, though not forced. Fused relatives are the only construction in which this paper keeps it (Figure 6).

A dependency grammar has drawn the same line. In Word Grammar a word may depend on a word that depends on it, and Gisborne (2026, p. 2) argues that such mutual dependency should be dispreferred where an analysis without it is plausible and coherent. He gives it up for dependent interrogatives and keeps it for free relatives, where the *wh* word heads the construction and is also extracted, "the dependency variant of the 'fused relative' analysis" in *CGEL* (p. 16).[36]

[34] van Riemsdijk (2006, p. 351) notes two restrictions on these types that neither analysis predicts: a strong bias toward the universally quantified reading, and degradation when the matrix and embedded verbs differ, as in ?*I'll keep my bedroom* [*however dark you paint your study*].

[35] A constructional analysis reaches the same double relation by another route. Kim (2017, p. 376) makes the free relative construction a subtype of both the head-filler and the head-modifier constructions, so the relativized phrase is at once head and filler.

[36] The "fused word" analysis he considers, Tesnière's, is another notion: one morpho-phonological word realizing two syntactic words, as *we're* realizes *we* and *are*. He rejects it for relative pronouns for want of independent evidence such as commutation (p. 6).

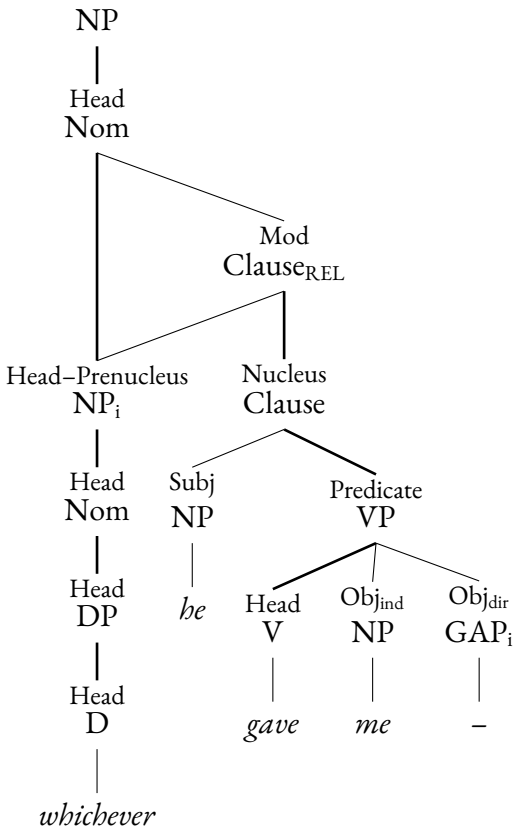


Figure 6: *Whichever he gave me* as this paper analyses it. Inside its NP, *whichever* is an ordinary head, where *CGEL* has a second fusion (p. 398). The NP is still head of the nominal and prenucleus of the relative clause at once, as in Figure 5a.

8 Conclusion

On the commitments held fixed in Section 2, this paper counts a property of form as evidence for a second function when it varies with that function and not with the word. Where *CGEL* fuses the head of a noun phrase with a modifier, as in *the lucky few* and *the rich*, it finds no such property, nor in Payne et al.'s *once*, *twice*, and *thrice*, whose term-of-office uses come out as ordinary modifiers (Sections 4 and 5). Where *CGEL* fuses it with the determiner, as in *take some*, it finds one: fusion derives the absence of an adjective before a bare determinative, where ordinary Head states a condition (Section 3). Against that one fact, which has an exception in *Poor everybody!*, ordinary Head gives *few* the same head relation in *few would dare*, *few of them*, *the few*, and *the lucky few*, where fusion gives it two different pairs of functions. The balance favours ordinary Head, though it doesn't force it (Section 6).

Noun-phrase fused relatives supply the evidence the criterion asks for, three times over (Section 7). The relative word's function inside its clause shows in subject relativization, in the ban on infinitival fused relatives, and, as a preference, in case. So fusion survives, favoured though not forced, as a device the grammar licenses for one construction, not as the general answer to a noun phrase with no noun.

These results hold *CGEL*'s categories fixed. In separate work I argue that determinatives are a kind of noun, beside common nouns, proper nouns, and pronouns. On that classification, a nominal headed by a determinative is headed by a noun, so the change of category, Payne et al.'s second departure, goes where a determinative heads the nominal, on both analyses, and only there. It remains where an adjective heads the nominal, as in *the rich*. That leaves ordinary Head with no departure from canonical structure for determinatives, while fusion keeps the first. The classification also gives a determinative the profile of a proper name: no determiner in its primary use (*few would dare*), and with one, as in *the few who did*, a secondary use where determiners are "selected in the ordinary way" ([*The Mary that you met yesterday*] *is my fiancée*; Huddleston and Pullum, 2002, pp. 520–521). For a compound such as *a special someone*, fusion would need conversion of the kind *CGEL* uses for *a nobody* (p. 423 n. 43), since a fused determiner-head doesn't otherwise take a determiner and an adjective before it. Nothing in the argument above depends on the classification.

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